

5. Treat it like the job it is

Once you've established the mind-set that shopping is a responsibility and a job, start considering what someone who has this type of job would need, to do to pull it off successfully. Establishment of line items, awareness of whether your budget has been over or under for a particular line item each month, workable filing system for bills . . . these are all areas you need to be aware of and have the tools to implement properly.

6. Develop a knowledge of liquidation value

This strategy can be applied to educational materials, literature, vehicle purchases, and other critical items in your life. One area where it might not occur to everyone is with antique shopping. I'm not talking about the ultra-high-end antiques necessarily, although this applies to them, too. I have repeatedly seen antique bureaus, tables, and chairs for the same price (and in some cases, less than) as some of the newer furniture items in popular stores and galleries. Some items are even equivalent in

price to lower-end assemble-yourself particleboard items from department stores.

Why is this important? Antiques hold their value, and in many cases increase in value. If you are going to spend \$180 on a lower-quality particleboard bookcase or kitchen table anyway, consider hitting a roadside antiques shop. You'll at least be able to get your money out of it later if necessary, and you know it has a better likelihood of standing the test of time.

7. Be aware of regular and exceptional market prices

You may be able to keep the prices on items you regularly purchase in your head. For others, you may want to implement a price book. The point is, if you are informed, you never have to pay full market value again. Ever. No more getting sucked into a bogus buy-one-get-one free special at the grocery store that has actually increased your per pound rate by 70 cents. No more inflated so-called "discounts." You will know an excellent deal when you see one.

